

Home Lab Project Week 7, Day 3

Task:

Analyze the captured traffic and identify the network artifacts associated with exploit delivery, communication, and the resulting session.

What "Connection failed" means here. This is a step earlier than the vsftpd attempt. With vsftpd, Metasploit connected and then decided the target wasn't vulnerable. Here it couldn't even connect to port 5432. That means one of three things:

1. **PostgreSQL isn't installed/running** on your Ubuntu target, so nothing is listening on 5432. Most likely.
2. PostgreSQL is running but **only listening on localhost** (127.0.0.1), not on the network — this is actually PostgreSQL's default, secure behavior, so even if it's installed it won't accept a connection from Kali.
3. A firewall is blocking 5432.

Check which it is. From Kali:

```
nmap -sV -p 5432 192.168.78.5
```

- If it says **closed** or **filtered**, there's nothing to exploit there — PostgreSQL isn't reachable (cases 1 or 2).
- If it says **open** with a version, then it's listening and the failure is something else (like auth), and we'd look closer.

Here's the thing worth saying plainly: this is the **third exploit against a target that is a clean, patched Ubuntu VM** (vsftpd backdoor, then PostgreSQL, both failing to connect). A current Ubuntu install doesn't ship with the deliberately vulnerable services these exploits need. I can keep trying exploits, but a hardened target won't hand a session, and each attempt will end the same way.

This loops back to what we set up DVWA for. That's the piece that gives a *genuinely* vulnerable target I can actually get a session on, which is what Week 7 Day 3 needs. The postgres exploit also has a prerequisite the vsftpd one didn't: it needs **valid PostgreSQL credentials** even when the port is open, so it's not a simple "fire and done" module.